government by virtually questioning its legitimacy. It couldn't have come at a worse time for a government under siege. In 2010, the UPA was hobbled by a series of big-ticket corruption allegations. The Delhi Commonwealth Games saw the organizing committee chairperson and Congress MP Suresh Kalmadi being charged with fraud. He was arrested in April 2011, just as the Anna movement first exploded. I had known Kalmadi from my days as a reporter in Mumbai in the early 1990s. He would send us invites for his annual Ganesh celebrations in Pune. 'Come and enjoy, we will look after everything,' he would tell the media. I did partake of his hospitality once and then went on to write a slightly critical story. He was fuming. 'What is this, Rajdeep? We organize the food and drink, and then you turn against us!'

He clearly relished living king-size. The Commonwealth Games for him was not about making money (he had made enough)—it was primarily about power and stature. He was taken up with the idea of rubbing shoulders with British royalty, of being seen as the czar of Indian sport. He liked distributing largesse to friends. 'I want everyone to have a good time,' he said with a laugh. It was this '*sab chalta hai*' brazen attitude that would lead to his downfall.

The bearded Kalmadi with his wicked-looking smile was pitched as the villain of the Commonwealth Games. I remember him asking me once why he was being singled out. 'My CWG budget is much less than the Delhi government, but still you only focus on me. What about Sheila Dikshit?' he asked. My answer was simple. 'Sir, life is about perception. When people see Sheilaji, they are reminded of their *dadima*. When they see you on television, they are convinced you must be a crook!' I am not sure my answer amused him.

Kalmadi wasn't the only Maharashtra politician in trouble. In November 2010, Maharashtra chief minister Ashok Chavan was made to resign over allegations that he had misused his power while allotting flats to the Adarsh cooperative society in Mumbai. That very month, the Union telecom minister A. Raja resigned over a report by the Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) on 2G spectrum allocation.